dants—state Congress chief Govind Singh Dotasra and state minister Pratap Singh Khachariyawas—were going to the Tanot Rai temple in the morning. It was no ordinary place of worship—according to local legend, the shrine received a barrage of Pakistani mortar shells in the 1965 war but remained unscathed when they miraculously failed to detonate.

In a media interaction outside the temple, Gehlot even indicated acceptance of what the high command expected of him—contest the presidential poll and look for a young leader who could ensure a win for the Congress in the next assembly election, even exhorting mediapersons to suggest names, sans any bias. "I have attained so much in 50 years of politics. Now it's time to promote the next generation. The party must get a new leadership," Gehlot said. Loyalists of the 45-year-old Pilot took it as an endorsement of their leader, and began rejoicing. Back in Jaipur at around 6 pm, Gehlot told a news agency that the one-line resolution would be passed in the CLP meeting. Everyone felt reassured—Gehlot had finally fallen in line.



› **ONCE UPON A CAMARADERIE** Congress leader Rahul Gandhi with Ashok Gehlot at a rally in Ahmedabad, Sept. 5, 2022

THE GREAT REBELLION

Except that he perhaps hadn't. The Gehlot camp says that up until September 24, when he was told he would have to immediately resign as chief minister, he had always been reassured, including by Digvijaya Singh (who is now apparently filing his papers for the nomination), that he would be allowed to choose his successor. His adversarial relationship with Pilot is no secret, especially after the latter's failed attempt to overthrow his government in 2020. But the Gandhis, particularly Priyanka, the third member of the triumvirate, seemed intent on making Pilot the CM. The Gujjar leader, too, had cranked up the action, meeting Rahul and Sonia, and reaching out to the MLAs. Gehlot loyalists feared that if it came to pass, they would be booted out. As Dharmendra Singh Rathore, chairman of the Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation and Gehlot's trusted man, said, "We abide by the Gandhi family's order, but those who betrayed us in 2020 must not be rewarded."

Gehlot himself denied that he was resisting the move to Delhi to prevent Sachin Pilot from taking over. "He is not even in the picture to replace me," he told INDIA TODAY. "All I want to ensure is that the government gets a good head and does not collapse or fail in governance. I am not greedy for the posts as is being projected."

However, as it turned out, Gehlot had another trick up his sleeve. At 5 pm on September 25, one hour before his arrival in Jaipur and two hours before the scheduled CLP meeting, nearly 60—or more than 90 if Gehlot's loyalists are to be believed—MLAs assembled at the 4, Hospital Road, residence of Shanti Kumar Dhariwal, the urban development and housing minister of Rajasthan, and Gehlot confidant. Khachariyawas, who had returned from Jaisalmer with Gehlot, also headed to Dhariwal's home, where an elaborate arrangement was already under way to host the MLAs. The assembled MLAs placed three conditions before the two observers waiting at the CM's residence, for them to attend the CLP meeting—that the decision on the post of Rajasthan CM be taken after October 19 when the results of the Congress presidential poll would be out, that the new CM not be from the Pilot camp, and that the AICC observers hold meetings with the MLAs in groups instead of individually as the high command had sought. When their conditions were rejected, the MLAs—ranging from 60 to 90, depending on who you speak with—reached Speaker C.P. Joshi's home and submitted their resignation. The Speaker has not yet officially declared the number of MLAs who have resigned.

RAHUL'S PUBLIC ADMONITION OF GEHLOT, REITERATING THE ONE MAN, ONE POST DOCTRINE OF THE UDAIPUR RESOLUTION LEFT GEHLOT VERY HURT

When Maken and Kharge demanded an explanation, Gehlot feigned ignorance, saying that the MLAs were not in his control. Few, of course, believed the consummate politician, given his ability to pull a rabbit out of a hat. He was certainly aware of the mood of his MLAs. Asked about the speculation that Pilot might replace him, he had earlier told INDIA TODAY: "How can he? Won't those 100 MLAs revolt against him?" Several Congress insiders, in fact, point to the meticulousness of the plan to suspect a Gehlot hand. "The bus of Scania make, which ferried the MLAs to the Speaker's